

A&R; Report: Rema

Date: 2026-05-18
Triage score: 67/100
Recommendation: WATCH
Genre: afrobeats
Generated by: A&R; Intelligence Agent (Spotify + Last.fm + NewsAPI + YouTube + Pinecone)

A&R; INTELLIGENCE REPORT: REMA

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Rema is an established Nigerian afrobeats artist with 3.94M monthly Spotify listeners and significant mainstream crossover success via "Calm Down (with Selena Gomez)" (6.36M plays). With a triage score of 67/100, **the recommendation is WATCH**. While the artist demonstrates strong commercial performance and international appeal, current label status requires verification—Rema appears to be signed to Jonzing World/Mavin Records/Universal Music Group, making them ineligible for Believe's independent artist mandate. This report proceeds with analysis assuming independent status for evaluation purposes, but label verification is critical before any engagement.

2. ARTIST OVERVIEW

Genre & Style: Afrobeats, trap, Nigerian pop
Origin: Nigeria
Career Stage: Established/mainstream breakthrough
Current Label Status: **REQUIRES VERIFICATION** (appears major label affiliated)

Rema operates at the intersection of traditional afrobeats and contemporary trap influences, with audio features showing 65% danceability, 70% energy, and 120 BPM tempo. The artist has achieved significant crossover success in Western markets, evidenced by the Selena Gomez collaboration which accounts for 30% of total Last.fm playcount (6.36M of 21.02M total plays).

3. STREAMING ANALYSIS

- Spotify Metrics:
- Monthly listeners: 3,943,792
 - Followers: 985,948
 - Follower velocity: +12% (estimated proxy)
 - Popularity score: 55/100
 - Active markets: 5
- Listener Engagement:
- Weekly listeners: 985,948 (proxy used for monthly calculation: $985,948 \times 4 = 3.94M$)
 - Total Last.fm playcount: 21,023,387
 - Plays per listener ratio: 21.3 (indicating strong repeat listening)

Top Track Performance:

1. "Calm Down (with Selena Gomez)" - 6.36M plays, 643,754 listeners (popularity: 64)
2. "Calm Down" (original) - 2.18M plays, 245,582 listeners (popularity: 24)
3. "Dumebi" - 1.22M plays, 136,218 listeners (popularity: 13)
4. "Soundgasm" - 1.28M plays, 134,500 listeners (popularity: 13)
5. "Charm" - 1.17M plays, 112,134 listeners (popularity: 11)

The dramatic popularity drop from the Selena Gomez collaboration (64) to catalog tracks (13-24) suggests heavy reliance on the crossover single for current streaming performance. The 12% follower velocity indicates moderate growth momentum.

4. PRESS & MEDIA ANALYSIS

Coverage Metrics:

- Total articles: 28
- Tier 1 outlets: 2
- Tier 2 outlets: 0
- Blog/Tier 3: 26
- Press score: 25/100
- Recency score: 0.643
- Sentiment: Neutral (0.0)

Recent Coverage:

- Rolling Stone: FIFA World Cup opening ceremony announcement
- Yahoo Entertainment: World Cup performance coverage

Outlet Distribution: Fox News, The Straits Times, Fox Sports, Asbury Park Press, RTE, Soompi, and various international outlets demonstrate global reach but limited music-focused editorial coverage.

Analysis: Press coverage is event-driven (World Cup performance) rather than music-release focused. The 25/100 press score and absence of Tier 2 coverage suggests limited sustained media relationships despite mainstream visibility. The 0.643 recency score indicates recent activity but not consistent press momentum.

5. DIGITAL PRESENCE

YouTube Metrics:

- Subscribers: 5,460,000
- Total views: 2,497,594,886 (2.5 billion)
- Video count: 194
- Upload frequency: Every 33 days
- Last upload: 31 days ago
- Recent video views: 85,245
- Top video views: 16,584,959

Analysis: YouTube presence is exceptionally strong with 2.5B total views and 5.46M subscribers, indicating established visual content strategy. The 33-day upload frequency shows consistent but not aggressive content cadence. However, recent video performance (85,245 views) is significantly below the top video benchmark (16.6M), suggesting either declining engagement or that recent uploads haven't yet gained traction. The subscriber-to-monthly listener ratio (5.46M:3.94M = 1.39:1) is unusually high, indicating YouTube may be a primary discovery platform.

6. ROSTER COMPARISON

Artist	Similarity	Genre	Listeners at Signing	Tier	Outcome
Temi Lagos	66.4%	Afrobeats	410,000	Premium Solutions	Success
Kofi Mensah	61.5%	Afrobeats	290,000	Premium Solutions	Developing
NTO	60.7%	Electronic	1,800,000	Premium Solutions	Success

Analysis: Rema's 3.94M monthly listeners significantly exceed comparable afrobeats signings (Temi Lagos: 410K, Kofi Mensah: 290K). The closest scale comparison is NTO (1.8M), who achieved success at Premium Solutions tier. Both successful afrobeats comparisons (Temi Lagos, Kofi Mensah) were signed at substantially smaller scale, suggesting Rema represents a different risk/investment profile—either a major acquisition opportunity or an artist already beyond independent label scope.

7. RISK FACTORS

1. Label Status Uncertainty (CRITICAL): Available data suggests major label affiliation (Jonzing World/Mavin Records/Universal Music Group). If confirmed, artist is ineligible for Believe services. This is a disqualifying risk that must be resolved immediately.
 2. Hit Dependency: The Selena Gomez collaboration accounts for 30% of total plays and has 2.6× the popularity score (64 vs. 24) of the next track. Catalog depth beyond this crossover moment is unproven, with remaining top tracks showing 13-24 popularity scores.
 3. Growth Plateau Indicators: The 12% follower velocity is moderate but not exceptional for an artist at this scale. Recent YouTube video performance (85K views) is 99.5% below top video performance (16.6M), suggesting potential engagement decline or algorithm challenges.
 4. Press Momentum Gap: Despite 3.94M monthly listeners, the artist generated only 2 Tier 1 articles and 0 Tier 2 coverage, with a 25/100 press score. This suggests limited music media relationships and potential difficulty sustaining narrative beyond event-driven coverage (World Cup).
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8. RECOMMENDATION

Recommendation: WATCH

Based on the triage score of 67/100, Rema falls into the WATCH category. This recommendation is appropriate for the following reasons:

Rationale for WATCH status:

- Artist scale (3.94M monthly listeners) exceeds typical Premium Solutions signing threshold (>500K), indicating established commercial presence
- Strong YouTube foundation (5.46M subscribers, 2.5B views) demonstrates proven audience-building capability
- International crossover success via Selena Gomez collaboration shows mainstream potential
- However, hit dependency, moderate growth velocity (12%), and weak press infrastructure (25/100 score) prevent immediate SIGN recommendation

Critical Next Steps:

1. ****IMMEDIATE:**** Verify label status—if major label affiliated, artist is ineligible
2. Monitor next release performance without Selena Gomez feature to assess catalog strength
3. Track follower velocity over next 90 days to confirm growth trajectory
4. Assess whether artist is seeking label services or already fully serviced

If Independent: Artist would qualify for Premium Solutions tier given >500K monthly listeners. However, at 3.94M scale, partnership would require significant investment and the artist likely has multiple competitive offers.

Strategic Consideration: The 67/100 triage score appropriately reflects an established artist with proven commercial success but unclear independent status and moderate growth momentum. WATCH status allows monitoring of next release cycle and label situation clarification before committing resources.

9. DATA SOURCES & CONFIDENCE

Data Sources:

- Spotify: Artist profile, monthly listeners, followers, popularity scores
- Last.fm: Playcount data (21.02M plays), listener counts, track-level performance
- YouTube: Channel metrics via official API
- Press monitoring: 28 articles across tier 1, tier 2, and blog sources
- Believe roster database: 5 similarity matches with historical signing data

Methodology Notes:

- Monthly listeners calculated as weekly listeners × 4 (proxy method noted)
- Follower velocity marked as estimated (12%)
- Audio features averaged across available tracks
- Press recency score: 0.643 (recent activity weighted)

Confidence Level: MEDIUM-HIGH (75%)

High Confidence Elements:

- Streaming numbers (Spotify + Last.fm cross-verification)
- YouTube metrics (official API data)
- Track performance rankings and play counts
- Roster similarity matching

Medium Confidence Elements:

- Follower velocity (estimated proxy, not direct measurement)
- Monthly listener calculation (weekly × 4 proxy)
- Label status (requires independent verification)

Data Limitations:

- No direct monthly listener growth trend data
- Limited historical performance data for trajectory analysis
- Press sentiment scored as neutral (0.0) may lack nuance
- Active markets count (5) without geographic breakdown

Recommendation: Before advancing from WATCH to any action, obtain: (1) confirmed independent label status, (2) direct monthly listener trend data for 6-month period, (3) next single release performance data, (4) management/representation details.